

How the Caucus Will Decide Awards

This is an overview of the process by which each caucus will decide the Grand Award-winning projects. For operational details, please see the other documents within Section V of the *Judge Information Board*.

Grand Awards

ISEF recognizes four different Grand Award levels: First, Second, Third, and Fourth Award. Typically, each category will have only a single First Award, though the categories with the largest number of projects will have two projects receive First Award. The number of projects at each award level increases as we move from First through Fourth Award, so that in the end, about one-quarter of all projects will be given a Grand Award. The number of awards at each level in your category will be shown to the caucus at the beginning of the Wednesday afternoon meeting where these awards will be determined.

Caucuses will decide each level award in order, starting with First Award and ending with Fourth Award. The process will be described below for a single award level. Other than the number of projects and awards at each level, the process is identical for all four levels.

The Need for Structure

In 2023, the number of projects in each category ranges from 37 to 86, averaging 63. Each judge will see only about one-quarter of all of the projects in their category, yet will be asked to vote on awards to candidate projects regardless of whether they interviewed the candidates. It is impossible for anyone to actively consider all of the projects in the category at once, even for the smallest categories. Consequently, when deciding which projects should receive a specific Grand Award, caucuses will make use of a tool to focus attention on a subset of all projects, where all judges *can* actively consider all candidate projects at once.

Central Organizing Principle – The Pool of Award Candidates

That tool to focus attention during the caucusing is The Pool of Award Candidates. Exactly as the name implies, it is a relatively small collection of projects that the caucus deems worthy of considering as serious candidates for the current award level.

In order to be useful, it is important that the number of projects placed into the Pool for a given award level not be significantly larger than the number of projects that will be awarded at that level. Caucuses that make productive use of this organizing principle usually finish all of their award decisions sooner and end with judges more satisfied with the caucus results. Caucuses which disregard this advice sometimes do so under the misimpression that collecting all possible award winners and talking about them at the start will allow them to save time on the back end. In fact, the data show exactly the opposite result. Caucuses which construct oversized Pools of Award Candidates consistently take longer to reach consensus for their awards, and usually end with more dissatisfaction among its judges.

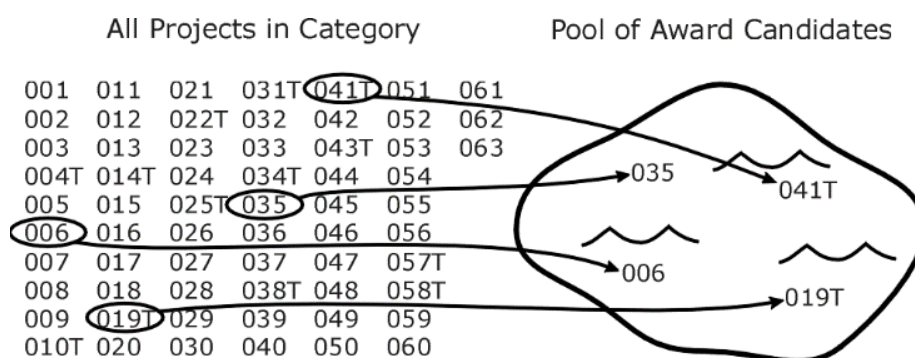
Two-Phase Selection Process

Use of the Pool of Award Candidates follows a simple two-phase process. The first phase grows the Pool by adding projects that the caucus deems worthy of a fuller discussion. After the Pool has been constructed, the second phase consists of fully discussing the merits of the contending projects and then selecting the project (or projects) that will be awarded.

Phase I: Growing the Pool

Consider the process of selecting First Award in an average-sized category. There are too many projects to discuss all of them, even superficially, so the caucus is presented with a ranked list of all projects, together with a brief project title and other information regarding the distribution of ranks derived from all interview scores. In order to permit discussion of project merits in depth, a Pool of Award Candidates must first be constructed.

Project ranking information and a brief discussion of project merits should be all that is necessary for the caucus to decide whether a given project is worthy of more in-depth consideration. At this point, the emphasis is on there being a *brief* discussion. All proposed additions to the Pool must be voted on by the entire caucus. Below is a schematic view of the projects in the category and the selection of some of them into the Pool.



While the process for First Award shown here lists all of the projects in the category on the left, during Phase I for lower-level awards, projects that have already been selected for awards will not be included in the list presented in the caucus room.

As noted above, care must be taken to avoid growing the Pool too large for the number of awards allocated to the category at the current level. For First Award, typically 2-4 projects will make up the entire Pool. For lower awards, the size of each Pool should not greatly exceed the number of awards to be given at the given level.

Generally speaking, projects considered for addition to the Pool should be among those unawarded projects that are most highly ranked. On occasion, however, a judge will propose a project not near the top of the ranked list for addition to the Pool. Lower-ranked projects can be considered for addition into the Pool of Award Candidates, but the low ranking itself must be addressed. Is there a reason to believe that the scores given to the project do not reflect the true quality of the project? The lower a project is ranked, the more important it becomes for the caucus to be convinced that its low rank is a misleading indicator of its quality in order for it to be added into the Pool. Low ranks are given for a reason. Overcoming them similarly requires a reason.

Jumping low-ranked projects over higher-ranked projects that are thereby denied consideration for awards is a too-frequent source of judge discontent with caucus procedures. This is not to say that ranks should determine awards. Rather, the point is that low ranks should not be ignored in nominating projects to the Pool. Low-ranked projects face a hurdle, but one that can be overcome given sufficient evidence. The lower the rank, the higher the hurdle.

At some point the caucus will decide to stop growing the Pool and move to Phase II of the award selection process.

Phase II: Selecting the Awardee(s)

When the caucus moves to Phase II, you will be presented with a set of three tables, with our above example shown schematically on the right. Initially, the top and bottom tables will be empty, while all of the projects that the caucus added to the Pool will be listed in the middle table.

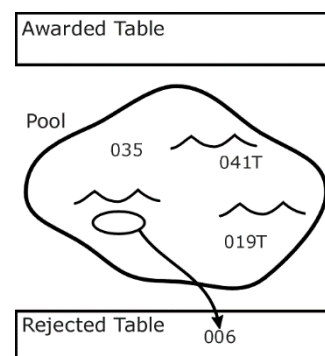
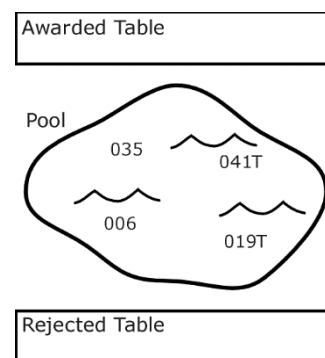
We emphasize at the outset that the caucus's only goal now is to promote the correct number of projects to the Awarded Table to receive the current level award. The order of adding projects to the Awarded Table does not matter. All projects selected for the same award will receive identical awards and public recognition. Anything the caucus does other than promoting projects to the Awarded Table is of secondary importance.

Since the discussion of all of the projects during Phase I was necessarily brief, the caucus should first consider the merits of all of the projects in the Pool and should *not* rush to judgement about the award-worthiness of any of the candidates. If there are projects in the current Pool that were already thoroughly discussed when they were in the Pool for a higher-level award, the caucus will usually be better served spending its time discussing the merits of other projects which were not contained in an earlier award Pool. Nevertheless, projects that were discussed earlier should not be ignored. Frequently, but not always, they will be selected for the current level award before newly-added projects.

Sometimes the caucus discussion leads directly to the selection of the full number of award winners. After promoting each to the Awarded Table, it is time to move on to the next lower award level.

Other times, however, the caucus will not be able to reach a consensus on promoting *any* project over the others. In such cases it may prove easier to reach consensus on which project (or projects) do *not* deserve to be promoted, and should be demoted. Projects demoted are then no longer allowed to be considered for the current award, though they may again be considered for any lower level award. The result of demoting a project, in this case project 006, is shown on the right.

We emphasize that demoting a project to the Rejected Table is never required. It is merely an option that the caucus may choose to use in order to make forward

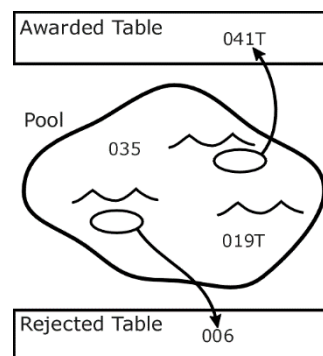


progress. Often, award decisions can be made without demoting any project to the Rejected Table.

Eventually the caucus will reach consensus on giving the award to a particular project, which the caucus effects by promoting it to the Awarded Table. In the example shown on the right, project 041T has been selected for the award under consideration.

If this promotion completes the set of awards for the current award level, then the co-chairs will finalize this level which moves the caucus on to the next lower award level.

IMPORTANT: The caucus should *not* “clean up” the remaining projects by restoring rejected projects to the Pool nor by demoting projects in the Pool to the Rejected Table. The location of each project at this point reflects the conscious decisions made by the caucus. Those decisions should not be undone and will impact what happens next.



Moving on to the Next Lower-Level Award

After the set of awardees at the current level is finalized:

- Projects that were left in the Pool remain in the Pool for the next lower level award, but
- Projects that were demoted to the Rejected Table are not included in the Pool. These projects will be included on an equal footing with all other unawarded projects in contention for the next lower level award.

In the example of the last diagram above, the initial Pool of Award Candidates for the next lower-level award will consist of projects 035 and 019T, while project 006 will be eligible for inclusion in the Pool along with all other remaining unawarded projects in the category.

At the conclusion of the Fourth Award decisions, all unawarded projects are treated identically, regardless of any project’s status of being included in any level Pool.

Points of Emphasis

1. Caucus discussion is facilitated by the use of a Pool of Award Candidates and a two-phase selection process which proceeds identically at all four award levels.
2. Phase I, “Growing the Pool,” involves adding candidate projects to the Pool after relatively brief discussions in which the caucus determines likely award-worthiness.
3. Phase II, “Selecting the Awardee(s),” involves extensive discussion of the merits of each project in the Pool before selecting one or more of them for the award.